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Defining a problem we can work on

Core 06: exploring a practical problem, comparing options and choosing a reasonable attempt.

Purpose of this unit

Help the client describe a specific practical difficulty and choose a step within their influence. Problems may require help or external change; personal work cannot resolve every situation.

Connecting with previous work

Open with SES-S01 and explore any barrier from Core 5. Choose one problem the client wants to address, separating the situation's description from a global judgment about themselves.

Suggested sequence

1. Define what happens, in what context and the desired practical outcome.
2. Explore what can be influenced and what requires another person or a missing resource.
3. Generate several options before choosing, including support and adjusted conditions.
4. Compare potential benefits, effort, limitations and consequences.
5. Choose an option, plan the first step and how to review the outcome. Close with SES-S02.

When the problem is undefined

Narrow it to a specific example. Saying I cannot manage anything does not define a problem for solution planning. If another emotional or professional need emerges, change focus rather than complete the sheet.

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Options and considerations before choosing

These fictional examples do not recommend a particular solution.

Group	A possible problem and directions to explore
Children	Remembering an item for an activity is difficult. Explore preparation in an agreed place or an adult's reminder. Compare what fits the child and family; responsibility does not pass entirely to the child.
Adolescents	Several tasks are due together. Explore priorities, a small first part or coordination with the school. Check what can actually change.
Adults	Coordinating commitments is difficult. Options may include reducing scope, dividing a task or requesting coordination, within existing roles and agreements.
Older adults	Reaching an important activity is difficult. Explore transport, timing or desired help, without assuming family is available or that the solution depends only on the person.

Choosing does not mean finding a perfect solution

Choose a reasonable approach and try it for an agreed time or scope. Sometimes more information is needed first. Explain and agree on postponement; do not mark the problem resolved.

Comparing in simple language

Ask what each option might enable and require. There is no need for a total score, formula or ranking that implies more precision than the available information.

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Adaptations and distinguishing types of difficulty

Adapt the process to the client and their actual circumstances.

Group	Practical adaptation
Children	Offer a few concrete options, spoken completion and adult support as needed. Do not make the child resolve disputes or responsibilities that are not theirs.
Adolescents	Distinguish personal wishes from institutional requirements. Preserve choice and clarify limits on sharing and coordination with others.
Adults	Explore authority, resources, demands and actual consequences. Good intentions do not establish feasibility or control.
Older adults	Offer a comfortable comparison and writing method, preserving preferences and independence. Choosing help does not negate ability.

When another response is needed

Harm, missing basic resources or difficulties requiring other expertise may need appropriate support or referral. The form does not replace professional assessment or assume every problem can be solved in the session.

When overwhelmed or stuck

Narrow the problem, separate what can be examined from what remains unknown, or pause the choice. A decision is not required just to complete the last line.

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Trying and reviewing what changed

CORE-06-P records an attempt in relation to the problem and desired outcome.

Before trying

Specify a step, time, help and how to describe the outcome. Check understanding of the choice and possible adjustments. Do not assume another person's cooperation without suitable coordination.

Back in the session

Compare events with the practical goal. Distinguish an unsuitable solution, changed conditions and an unattempted plan. Keep, adapt or replace it, or seek needed help.

Connection to the next unit

Trying a solution tests how well an approach fits. Core 7 asks a different question: examining an expectation through a planned experiment. Not every problem-solving attempt needs to become a behavioral experiment.

Content status

Original drafts for professional and rights reviews. They provide no diagnostic score, promise of resolution or professional-use approval already granted.

General sources for further reading

Beck Institute: Selecting Techniques in CBT
General background on selecting an appropriate focus and approach.
https://beckinstitute.org/blog/selecting-techniques-in-cbt/

Beck Institute Cares: What Are CBT Sessions Like?
Background on planning action and learning from it.
https://cares.beckinstitute.org/about-cbt/what-are-sessions-like/

Consulted: 03 Nov 2026. Sources neither license external forms nor validate the kit or its age adaptations.

Reviewer's name, role, date and versions reviewed:

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